

THIS SPRING, AS THE SNOW STARTED MELTING in the middle Himalayas, the political temperature in Himachal Pradesh, as if on cue, kept rising. It started with the Bharatiya Janata Party's stunning capture of a Rajya Sabha seat for Harsh Mahajan—a former close aide of former Congress CM Virbhadra Singh—with the help of disgruntled Congress MLAs on February 27. It set the stage for a charged campaign for the Lok Sabha polls in the only northern state ruled by the Congress.

Though the incipient rebellion against Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu was patched up through troubleshooting by veteran Congress leaders, enabling the CM to cling on, the embarrassing episode has shaken party morale. Himachal Pradesh sends four MPs to the Lok Sabha. The Congress is defending the Mandi seat, which state unit chief Pratibha Singh, widow of Virbhadra, won in the bypolls in November 2021. Otherwise, the BJP has dominated Lok Sabha polls in the state, scoring 4-0 clean sweeps in 2014 and 2019. Riding on a high-pitched Hindutva narrative, it increased its vote share by 16 percentage points in 2019, scoring a stunning 70 per cent.

However, in the assembly polls of December 2022, the Congress managed to get the better of the BJP challenge led by then incumbent CM Jai Ram Thakur, capturing 40 seats in the 68-member legislative assembly. The Congress fought as a cohesive unit and circumvented the Hindu nationalism agenda of the BJP by highlighting governance issues.

On June 1, along with the four LS seats (Shimla, Hamirpur, Kangra and Mandi), bypolls will also take place for six assembly seats in Himachal. All six seats were held by Congress candidates who cross-voted for Mahajan and against their own candidate Abhishek Manu Singhvi in the Rajya Sabha polls, put the Sukhu government in danger and were suspended. They later joined the BJP. In the 68-member assembly, the BJP has 25 MLAs and three independents. It's believed that Sukhu needs to win at least three assembly seats out of the six, along with all LS seats, to save his job. The former will maintain his majority in the assembly; parliamentary victories will ensure he remains in the high-command's good books. At present, a jittery Sukhu is trying his best to repeat the 2022 game plan, trying to stick to local issues to curtail the impact of such "achievements" touted by its rival as construction of the Ram temple.

The BJP is not taking things lightly either—it announced its candidates on March 24, giving them enough time to campaign. As former CM Thakur made it clear, all four BJP candidates will bank on PM Modi's popularity and charisma. "PM Modi is a big factor... he will form the next government. The BJP's target is to win 400 seats; four of them will come from Himachal," claims Thakur. Saying that PM Modi's image as a global leader "will have a major impact on the electorate", he lists the BJP's 'achievements'—abrogation of Article 370, construction of Ram temple, women's reservation in Parliament and the Indian economy becoming the fifth largest in the world. Can the faction-ridden Himachal Congress rise up to the challenge?

CM Sukhu is confident it can. "We delivered the old pension scheme, raised revenues by plugging leakages,

THE BIG ISSUES

BJP

- Making PM Modi the face of the campaign
- Playing up abrogation of Article 370, Ram mandir, social sector schemes
- Painting the Sukhu government as 'ineffective'; showing the Congress as a 'broken house'

CONGRESS

- Localising polls by raising constituency- related issues
- Not taking on PM Modi's popularity by not attacking him directly
- Making party heavy-weights contest the Lok Sabha polls